

JAMES FRANCIS

Interview - July 15, 1937

RA-4RD 18

THINGS TO ASK ABOUT AMONG PEOPLE LIVING WITHIN REACH OF THE RESETTLEMENT ADMINISTRATION PROJECT CALLED ROANOKE FARMS.

Original marginal note: "(Very prosperous farmer--two story house--carbide lights--married Pearl Clanton.)"

Editorial note: This is a clean typed-text edition transcribed from the five-page historical scan. Original wording and period terminology are preserved. Unclear or cut-off text is identified rather than guessed.

When you go to see somebody that you think will know something about old times ask him or her as many of these questions as you can and write down the answers.

1. What was your father's name?

"Don't know for certain."

2. Who were his parents?

"Don't know."

3. What was your Mother's name?

"Josephine Scott--right around here."

4. Who were her parents?

"Taylor Harris was her father. Her husband was brother to one of original owners of the 2000 acre. Jackson Scott owned two acres of land when he died. Don't know her mother's name."

5. Where was your father born?

"Don't know."

6. Where was he raised?

"Don't know."

7. On whose place was he raised?

"Don't know."

8. What kind of work did he do?

"Don't know."

9. Is he living? If he is living, what is his age?

"Don't know." If he is dead, when did he die, and at what age?

10. Where was your mother born?

"Right around here."

11. Where was she raised?

"Same neighborhood."

12. On whose place was she raised?

"Don't know but think on Sheriff Dawson's farm."

13. What kind of work did she do?

"Farm."

14. Is she living? "No." If she is living, what is her age?

"Died in 1933--67 or 68 years old--she didn't know."

15. Who used to own the land you live on now?

"Norfleet's."

a. In slavery times?

"Norfleet's."

b. Shortly after freedom?

"Norfleet's."

c. How big was the place in slavery times?

"Big."

d. How many colored people did the owner have?

"Don't know."

e. Who owns it now?

"Norfleet's."

f. What crops did he raise?

"Cotton, peas--cotton and tobacco--I reckon, everybody raised."

g. What have you heard about the way they grew these crops?

"Same as always."

16. What are the names of all your brothers and sisters?

"Four half brothers--Samuel Scott, New York, truck driver. David Scott, Ayden, market. Solomon and Simeon Scott, both in Virginia, logging. Two half sisters--Sarah Liza Davis (Robt), Brinkleyville, has six children. Ella Davis (James), [remainder is cut off in the scan]."

17. Where do they all live?

(See above.)

18. What brothers and sisters did your father have and where did they live?

"Don't know."

19. What brothers and sisters did your mother have and where did they live?

"Don't know that she had any."

20. What church are you a member of?

"Daniel Chapel."

21. When was that church started?

"Don't know."

22. How many preachers that have been regular preachers at that church can you give the names of?

"Daniel Martin for fifteen or more years. Jim Arrington for four or five years maybe. Nick Arrington for fifteen or twenty years--all of fifteen anyhow. O. M. James for ten years. -- Branch stayed two years after O. M. James. No preacher at present."

23. Can you say how many years each one was preaching at that church?

(See above.)

24. How many people do you know that are still living in your neighborhood that used to be slaves?

"None that I know of."

25. Whose places were they on?

"Don't know."

26. Where do they live now?

"Don't know."

27. Have you heard anybody say who were good masters and who were bad masters?

"Don't know."

28. What did the good ones do?

"Don't know."

29. What did the bad ones do?

"Don't know."

30. When was the first colored school you ever heard of in that neighborhood started?

"Daniel's Chapel." Now a Rosenwald School with three hundred pupils and three teachers.

31. Who taught it?

"Don't know."

32. How many children went to it?

"Don't know."

33. When did the first public colored school get built?

"Don't know."

34. Where was it?

"Don't know."

35. Who do you think among all the colored people in your neighborhood has done the most for colored people around there?

"Don't know anybody. Everybody in this neighborhood cooperates in everything."

Additional Family and Farm Notes

"We have thirteen living children and one dead. Roy Francis, Newport News, hotel waiter, married, has two children, boy and girl. Morris Francis, Washington, was garage worker, married, one child, girl. James Grady Francis, truck driver, married, one child. Doris, lives with us most of the time. Eula Mae Copeland (Wilson), one of descendants of Rob't Copeland (grandson) who was one of the eight original owners of the 2000 acre tract. Lives in Washington, has two children, boy and girl. Willis Wilbert Francis, Norfolk, truck driver. Eddie Rufus Francis, farms here with me, married, has two children, girl and boy. Jesse A. Francis, farms with me here, goes to Durham to College, going to be dentist. Edward Mack Francis, fifteen, helps me farm. Erdie Lee Francis, nineteen, goes to school. Lillias Bell, seventeen, goes to school. Mattie, sixteen, goes to school."

(This family buys nothing but coffee, sugar, and tea. They exchange corn for flour, and also for mixed chicken feed. They do not raise tobacco because it's gambling crop. Have two hundred trees in orchard and grapes. They can 200 or 300 cans of vegetables out of garden each year. Have 300 chickens or more. Have modern farm equipment and five mules.)

Transcription note: The scan includes handwritten marks near the final farm note. These marks were not incorporated into the typed text because they are not fully legible.